them to escape even if they got wind of our movements during the night. In case anyone attempted to break through the cordon before daybreak, the person would be challenged and asked to stop. If the person tried to run away, we would first try and apprehend the individual, and when compelled, open fire. At night, the villagers generally stayed indoors and rarely ventured to go out. Besides, we had warned the people that in case of an emergency, they should make use of a lantern or torch while moving around. On the other hand, the terrorists moved about in a furtive manner at night and avoided making any noise. In fact, on many occasions, they ordered the Kashmiri villagers to do away with their dogs, so that their movements were not announced by the sound of barking.

After daybreak, we would enter the village and ask all men to assemble in a central place like a school or the Idgah. Women, children and the elderly were told to stay at home. We would then commence the search of the village in a systematic manner, based on the intelligence provided by the sources. Our endeavour was to prevent the trapped terrorists from moving from one hideout to the other. We had to isolate each locality or 'mohalla' before commencing search operations. It was ensured that a local police constable and a village elder accompanied every search party.

A clearance was obtained in writing after a house was searched so as to safeguard our soldiers from false accusations later. Many terrorists were detected and caught from hideouts and cavities cleverly made under the floor, behind the walls, or in the attics. Some were caught hiding in the cattle sheds. At times there were shootouts between our troops and the hiding terrorists. Some of these hideouts were very ingeniously configured and camouflaged, and thus remained undetected. Once a terrorist was captured from a house, the owner begged forgiveness. His plea would be that the terrorists threatened him with dire consequences if he refused to cooperate. That was indeed so in most cases – they had to acquiesce to save their lives.

While the search operation was on, it was my practice to address the men folk who had been assembled at a central place. Moreover, during this period, they were also screened individually and made